STATE SCAN

UP: RECLAIMING SAFFRON *PG 16*

PUNJAB: THE LONELINESS OF SUKHBIR BADAL *PG 18*



FESTIVE SPLENDOUR
A Durga Puja pandal in Kolkata in 2025

ANI

▶ WEST BENGAL

SUVENDU PLAYS THE PUJO CARD

The CM wants to leave his imprint on the first Durga Puja under the BJP—from a gala Modi show to the slaying of a few demons

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT'S ALMOST 'PUJO', A TIME WHEN THE AIR IN BENGAL THREATENS to take a turn towards the pleasant and sensory delights fill up a festive canvas. This year, there's another change in the weather report: it's the first Durga Puja under the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Politics has superintended culture in these parts since the days of the Left. The pattern deepened under the Trinamool Congress (TMC). All eyes, therefore, are on how the Suvendu Adhikari government will commandeer the state's grandest festival. The chief minister is keen on being seen as the prime agent of change in the way the puja is conducted and perceived. Beyond the administrative and the doctrinal, that's taking the shape of grand theatre.

The biggest pandal of them all, so to speak, may turn out to be at Eden Gardens, where a Mahalaya spectacle is being rustled up for October 10. There will be fireworks, drones—and plenty of triumphal conch-blowing. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will be in attendance, a marker of the axial shift in power. The revolution may be simulcast on a global canvas, say official sources, with